Start

your own business

TUM Alumna Maria Sievert holds a Bachelor in Civil Engineering and a Master in Industrial Engineering. In 2017, she set up inveox, a company now ranking as a global pioneer with its digital solutions for tissue samples.

TUM TIP

TUM offers extensive support for start-ups: *www.tum.de/innovation/entrepreneurship*

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An entrepreneur tells her story

How did you come to setting the company up?

Maria Sievert: My co-founder Dominik Sievert and I became aware independently of each other of the extensive problem of tissue samples becoming mixed up. As digital natives, it was clear to both of us that we needed to find a digital solution. We finally met through the Manage&More program of UnternehmerTUM. It was only when we combined our ideas, that a technically realizable solution and viable business model emerged. With these in our pocket, we went to TUM's start-up consulting. Here, we were given comprehensive advice on all aspects of the start-up phase and received valuable contacts from TUM's extensive network. Financially, we were supported by UnternehmerTUM's KICKSTART funding program and EXIST from the German Federal Ministry for Economic Affairs and Energy. To this day, we still maintain a lively dialog with various Chairs at TUM. Many of our working students come from there – and some stay on with us also when they have completed their degrees.

What do you see as the greatest challenge of being an entrepreneur?

From my perspective, the biggest challenge is the constant roller coaster ride between ups and downs. Every week, every day, every hour, every minute, important decisions have to be made that provide answers to the constantly changing demands and sometimes completely unpredictable challenges; to questions of funding, building the team, layoffs and dealing with the Corona pandemic. But every challenge also brings new opportunities. My company is not just a project, but my current life's mission, to which I have dedicated all my energy.

What advice would you give to young people thinking of starting a company?

The fact that we obtained masses of feedback on our business plan proved to be crucial for us. As a young entrepreneur, you often become professionally blind to the obvious in the start-up phase out of sheer zest and euphoria. At times like those, it's extremely valuable to draw on expert appraisals from TUM's wide network in order to obtain new points of view. Another sensible move is to turn to other entrepreneurs who are already a few steps further down the road. We also benefit a lot from their tips. Beyond that, the general advice must be to follow your passion. Passion is the driving force behind the start-up and the key to success. It's the foundation that ensures you can find a solution even to the toughest challenges.

www.community.tum.de/en/maria-sievert

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